Her Daddy's Eyes

By Gary E. Parker

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS 1: *Thirty years after Vietnam, the trauma of the war continues to haunt another generation of men and women - the estimated 120,000 sons and daughters who never saw action.*

ACTRESS 2: *For many families dealing with post-traumatic stress disorder in a time before it was recognized by the medical community, life with veteran fathers was a time bomb.*

ACTRESS 1: *Once loving fathers returned from war, snapping at the drop of a hat with no explanation . . . no warning. One minute a normal father and the next minute someone unrecognizable. How does a family cope?*

ACTRESS 2: *In Her Daddy's Eyes by Gary E. Parker, Allie Wilson, now 33 and her mother Gladys try to find the answers to a family that never was.*

Allie Wilson sits on the floor of her childhood bedroom in a pair of lightweight cotton pajamas. The tiny image of a blond-haired, green- finned mermaid--repeated over and over again--decorates the pajamas. The hems of the legs and the cuffs on the sleeves are frayed, thinned by years of wear and tear. A stack of books, picture frames, shoes, old baseball caps, and a cluster of other assorted items surround her on the floor. Allie hears footsteps and looks up as her mom, Gladys, enters the room.

GLADYS: I like your pajamas. [pointing to Allie's frayed nightwear.]

ALLIE: You should. You gave them to me.

GLADYS: Christmas--when you were thirteen.

ALLIE: *[smiling]* I always liked mermaids.

GLADYS: *[sitting beside her]* They're a bit snug in the backside now, I expect.

ALLIE: And a little short in the legs but not too bad.

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GLADYS: You got most of your height that year. Five ten by thirteen.

ALLIE: I'm wearing them for old times' sake.

GLADYS: I'm surprised you found them.

ALLIE: They were stuck in the back of a dresser drawer. You know me. I never throw anything away.

GLADYS: You're the queen of the pack rats.

ALLIE: *[surveying the clutter]* Until now.

GLADYS: *[surprised]* You're finally cleaning things out?

ALLIE: About time, don't you think?

GLADYS: *[laughing]* I guess a wedding in three weeks causes a girl to do all kinds of strange things.

ALLIE: *[holding up a pair of high heels]* You know anybody who can use these? I want to give away what I don't need anymore.

GLADYS: You can search the neighborhood for a tall Cinderella, I guess, but no short girl can wear these skis.

ALLIE: I bought those heels, what...twelve years ago?

GLADYS: The year you graduated from Furman.

ALLIE: I wore them the first game I ever coached; they made me taller than any of my players.

GLADYS: I'm glad you were never ashamed of your height.

ALLIE: You taught me not to slump.

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GLADYS: It's a good thing Trey is six three.

ALLIE: When he proposed he said. . . "It will make every guy I know green with envy. My marrying a woman who looks like a model, long and willowy, raven hair, eyes the color of black olives." But until recently I always said "I'm not ready yet," You know why.

GLADYS: Let me see, could it be that your father's abandonment of us when you were just four has caused you to become distrustful of the entire male species?

[Thoughtful silence for both women]

GLADYS: *[changing the subject]* You plan to leave anything here?

ALLIE: *[goes to closet and hauls out a stack of boxes from the far corner, then sits with Gladys to go through the contents. A bunch of pictures lay inside. Allie flipped quickly through the photos, most of them showing her in various states of shooting a basketball.]* I was a skinny thing.

GLADYS: Like a young filly. Still are, though you're not such a young filly anymore.

ALLIE: Hey, I'm just thirty-three!

GLADYS: Close to over-the-hill; in my day if a woman didn't marry by the time she turned thirty, she officially entered the ranks of the old maids.

ALLIE: Heaven forbid that should happen. *[Allie flips the top off another box. An old corsage, its flower long since dried, rests inside. Allie holds it to her nose, takes a breath, and imagines she can still smell the scent of the bloom.]* Tenth grade.

GLADYS: What was that boy's name?

ALLIE: Bill Stone. He moved away a couple of years later. Wonder what happened to him.

GLADYS: A keeper or a goner? *[pointing to the corsage]*

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ALLIE: *[waving it away]* "Bill Stone is a goner.

GLADYS: *[smiling]* You really are cleaning out, aren't you?"

ALLIE: *[opening another box with more pictures in it, black and white ones this time. Her brow furrowed as she fingers the top photo--a picture of her grandmom and granddad standing in front of the house where she now sits.]* What are these?

GLADYS: *[eyes widening]* I thought I'd lost these.

ALLIE: Have I ever seen these?

GLADYS: *[taking pictures as Allie passes them one by one]* I don't know.

ALLIE: *[thumbing through more pictures. Her fingers freeze as she stares at one in the middle of the stack. . . . softly]* It's Dad.

GLADYS: Let me have those! They're just old pictures . . No reason to drag them out now. *[Allie stands, keeping the photos from Gladys]* Give me the pictures. They're mine! *[reaching for the photos Allie is now holding over her head out of reach]*

ALLIE: Why don't you want me to see them?

GLADYS: It's just...there's no reason to drag out old memories, that's all.

ALLIE: *[Allie hands the pictures to Gladys]* I'd like to see them, but I'll do what you want. *[Gladys holds the photos for several seconds, then sighs and hands them back to Allie]*

GLADYS: It's Jack just before he left for Vietnam.

ALLIE: I've never seen this picture.

GLADYS: You weren't born yet. I didn't even know I was pregnant at the time.

ALLIE: You're pregnant in this?

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GLADYS: Just barely. I was nineteen years old, your dad too.

ALLIE: So he's the same age as you. Hard to believe.

GLADYS: You've never seen any of those. *[Allie thumbs through more pictures, then . . .]*

ALLIE: It's me. How old was I?

GLADYS: Three.

ALLIE: The year before dad left us?

GLADYS: Yes.

ALLIE: Do you have other pictures of me with dad?

GLADYS: Not many, perhaps a few.

ALLIE: Can I see them?

GLADYS: Of course you can.

ALLIE: Why haven't you shown them to me?

GLADYS: Didn't want you to remember bad things, to conjure up the fact that Jack left us. You want to see them now?

ALLIE: *[thinks for a moment then shakes her head]* Another time maybe.

GLADYS: Whenever you want.

ALLIE: Why did Dad leave us?

GLADYS: He had some troubles . . Brought them back from the war.

ALLIE: What kind of troubles?

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GLADYS: He never really told me.

ALLIE: Where did he go when he left us?

GLADYS: I don't know. He used to write every now and again.

ALLIE: *[softly]* I wish he could be here for my wedding

GLADYS: I wish he could have been here for a lot of things for you.

ALLIE: *[near tears]* What happened to him, Mom?

GLADYS: I wish I knew more, but I don't. He came back from Vietnam a broken man. Suffered nightmares, sweats, the shakes, took to drinking, maybe some drugs too. I never knew all of it.

ALLIE: Did he ever say what happened to him over there?

GLADYS: Not much. Just that it was rough.

ALLIE: Do you think he really loved us?

GLADYS: I know it's hard to believe since he left us, but I know he did. He used to tell me over and over again that we were the only things that kept him alive. He sent money to us for years after he left, even after he stopped writing. He loved us. I believe that even though I don't have a lot of ways to prove it.

ALLIE: Maybe he left us because he loved us.

GLADYS: How do you figure that?

ALLIE: Maybe he didn't want to put us through what we'd have to endure if he stayed around. A man on alcohol and drugs can cause a lot of trouble for loved ones. Maybe Dad figured leaving might hurt us less than staying. At least with him gone we could get on with our lives.

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GLADYS: That's one way to look at it.

ALLIE: *[looking again at the pictures]* Were his eyes as black as they look?

GLADYS: His eyes were as black as yours, like hockey pucks. Never seen anybody with eyes as dark as the two of you.

ALLIE: I've got his eyes.

GLADYS: I know, I just never wanted to tell you.

ALLIE: You think he's still alive?

GLADYS: I have no way of knowing.

ALLIE: I wish I knew one way or the other.

[Thoughtful silence for both Allie and Gladys]

GLADYS: *[breaking the silence]* You planning on spending the night?

ALLIE: Why not. I'm already in my pajamas.

GLADYS: Good to have you home. *[the women hug, Allie carefully puts the picture of her dad where she can see it on the night stand and returns to her cleaning, Gladys watches with a wistful smile on her face]* . . . well, I need to clean up the kitchen. *[Gladys exits]*

ALLIE: *[speaking to her father's picture]* I'm getting married . . . . Kind of scary.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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